

Spreadsheets and databases are in competition—they have similar features. Yet the way they work in the background is different. When you work in a spreadsheet, you view the data you are entering as a section. In a database, you only see the data you are entering—you have to request a report or different display to see more of the information. Other differences are:

- m Databases are more often used for applications with long textual entries
- m Very large applications (thousands of entries) are more often handled in databases
- m Spreadsheets are easier to learn to use and get calculations from than a database program

This last reason is why many researchers and students prefer spreadsheets for keeping track of their data over databases.

It is impossible to give a complete listing of applications that can be done using spreadsheets, but they include budgeting displays, checkbook registers, enrollment records, inventories, coded surveys, field and laboratory research data, and financial and accounting applications.

3.1.1 Basic Terms And Definitions

Cell

This is the basic unit of the spreadsheet. It is a location that can contain information, and is most often defined by its column and row address. For example, C6 represents a cell in the third column (column C) and sixth row. The naming convention for a cell reference is the alphabetic column letter position followed by the row number. C6 is correct but 6C is not. You may use either lower or upper case letters when referencing a column.

Active Cell Or Selected Cell

The cell with the dark border around it is the active cell. This is the cell that can be acted upon, and indicates where the insertion